designer a Buddhist, the construction company involved was a Parsi group; and the temple director is a Jain. The establishment of the largest Hindu temple in the Gulf by BAPS is notable since, among the 3.3 million-plus strong Indian diaspora in the UAE, hardly about 100-150 families are BAPS members.

TEMPLE IN THE DUNES

The BAPS Hindu Mandir is located in the Abu Mreikhah area on the outskirts of Abu Dhabi city. The 13.5 acres of land required for the temple was gifted by UAE president and ruler of Abu Dhabi, Sheikh Mohammed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, in 2019. Another 13.5 acres was acquired and the temple campus is now spread over 27 acres. The BAPS mandir is reportedly the 'first temple built with stone' with the architecture traditional, minimalistic and monolithic, the colour resembling the sand dunes. While the reigning deity is Lord Swaminarayan, there are also seven other shrines depicting seven Hindu deities on the premises.

The Rs 700 crore temple was built with donations and financial support by BAPS devotees and volunteers. "BAPS has a presence in over 50 countries, where people from various castes, races and religions have come forward to build mandirs and various other social-spiritual projects," claims Bansal. Indeed, the sect claims that all their funds come through donations from members and volunteers, who are encouraged to donate—a tithe, say 5-10 per cent of their income—to BAPS. Funds have never been a problem—the $96 million temple in Robbinsville, NJ, was apparently almost fully built with donations from followers (see *The BAPS Universe*).

Prime Minister Modi has attended several BAPS events in the past, but he is not the only leader who finds it politic to indulge the sect. The then president of India, the late A.P.J. Abdul Kalam, BJP leader L.K. Advani and then PM Manmohan Singh attended the inauguration of the Akshardham temple in Delhi in 2005. In 2007, then Canadian PM Stephen Harper inaugurated the BAPS mandir in Toronto. Incumbent PM Justin Trudeau has also visited BAPS temples multiple times. King Charles and wife Camilla have visited the Neasden Swaminarayan Temple in London more than once, while UK prime minister Rishi Sunak and his wife visited only one temple in India—the Akshardham temple in Delhi—during his state visit in 2023.

THE CONTROVERSIES

As BAPS cultivates such prominence, it has often drawn the limelight in more unfortunate ways. In September 2002, terrorists attacked the Akshardham temple in Gandhinagar, purportedly to avenge the post-Godhra riots. Thirty-three people died in the Akshardham attack, but all the accused were acquitted in 2014.

A section of the Hindu community



The Robbinsville Akshardham; (below) BAPS mandir, London

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THE BAPS UNIVERSE

- Sprung from a Vaishnavite sect set up in the early 1800s, BAPS now has a presence in 50+ countries, over a million members, 80,000 volunteers, a global network of over 1,550 mandirs and 5,025 centres
- Typically headed by *gunatit gurus* (spiritual leaders) of the sect, Mahant Swami Maharaj (Vinu Patel), the sixth spiritual successor of Lord Swaminarayan, has been heading it since 2016. His predecessor, Pramukh Swami Maharaj (Shantilal Patel), is particularly revered. He headed BAPS for 45 years as its spiritual leader, established 1,125 temples and also laid out the vision for the Abu Dhabi temple back in 1997
- The sect's revenues come from donations from members and volunteers among local communities wherever they're present. They encourage members to pay 'tithe'—5-10% of their income—as donation to the foundation
- Costs for the UAE temple, which took five years to build, were covered by donations from BAPS devotees and volunteers. The sect's largest global temple is in Robbinsville, New Jersey, US. Inaugurated in October 2023, it cost $96 million (Rs 797 crore)



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